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Al Chez

Trumpeter Al Chez has led an active career as a sideman with numerous groups, including Tower of Power and the Robert Cray Band, as a member of the David Letterman Band and as a leader of his own group, the Brothers of Funk. He frequently conducts clinics on jazz, drum corps performance and general musicianship.

Al was interviewed in New Hartford, NY on February 13, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Okay. My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive with Al Chez here in New Hartford High School band room. Thanks for driving all this way.

AC: Thank you. My pleasure. I love coming out to the schools and giving back to the different communities.

MR: So you, sir, have a set of iron chops.

AC: I don't know if they're iron. They hurt. You know that's a, they hurt. I've been playing a long time and I grew up playing you know in the drum & bugle corps and the marching band activity, and I got used to playing for 12 hours a day really early on in my career and that kind of — I kind of kept that going you know. Hard work, you know, you want to cash a check do the work. You know what I mean? So there you go.

MR: Isn't there some saying about brass players like if you don't practice one day you notice, two days the audiences notices, or something like that.

AC: Well I've been on vacation so, you know no. Yeah you've got to, you know, I guess it's like an athlete. Any athlete if you sit out, if an athlete goes on the disabled list he's going to come back and he's not going to be at his best. He's going to have to go to the minor leagues or he's going to have to go for a rehab a couple of games, and get his game back. I think it's the same thing with playing the trumpet. You have to stay up on your game. You have to — it's a full time job.

MR: Is it also part of physically keeping your — I mean I'm thinking about your lung power. Because I just watched, about half an hour ago I watched you playing "America" in this stadium.

AC: Oh that was, they asked me to do that about 15 minutes before I did it and I was like under the bleachers trying to figure out a good key.

MR: Well it turned out to be a pretty high key also.

AC: Yes it did, yes it did. So that was a lot of fun. That was a lot of fun. But yeah it's pretty physical. Everything — it's one of the reasons why I love playing the trumpet. It goes — it kind of goes through my whole body you know. I feel it. When I play it goes through everything. It goes through the physical aspect, it goes through my brain, it goes through

my soul, it goes through everything, and what comes out, every time I play, is something unique and different. And I embrace that too. I don't want to really — how do I put this the right way? I don't want to duplicate anything that I've done before because I've done that already. You know what I mean? So when I'm playing, every note, every solo, every phrase has its own — a life of its own. And I kind of dig that. You know what I mean? My favorite trumpet player is Louis Armstrong. Not because — well a couple of reasons. Louis Armstrong — there's never been another trumpet player to really duplicate that sound that he has. There's guys that sound like Maynard Ferguson. There's guys that sound like Doc Severinsen. There's guys that sound like Roy Hargrove. There's guys that sound like, you know, Wynton Marsalis. But there's been nobody who's really duplicated that Louis Armstrong kind of vibe, probably because he created that whole sound of his and he embraced the uniqueness. You know it's like he wasn't going to try to sound like this guy or this guy or this guy, he was going to try to sound like Louis Armstrong. And I kind of do that same thing. I don't want to sound like Maynard Ferguson, I don't want to sound like Bill Chase, I don't want to sound like Louis Armstrong. I want to sound like Al Chez. You know? And I want to hone my sound and I want to get it so that it goes through my soul properly and then every time I play something I want to change that a little bit. I want to keep working on, you know, that sound. Like that's the main thing for me, keep on working on my sound and my sound keeps evolving you know. Kind of like somebody who is learning. The smartest man in the world, the first thing he's going to tell you is I don't know everything. So he's going to keep learning. I'm going to keep evolving with my sound and have my sound keep on evolving. Now whether that's song to song, whether that's phrase to phrase, whether that's solo to solo, or measure to measure, or note to note, it keeps evolving. And I kind of dig that.

MR: Is your thought process when you're improvising different if you're playing sort of a typical jazz tune that has quite a few changes, perhaps one per measure or you know, two per measure, as opposed to soloing on a vamp, like one chord?

AC: Yeah. You're telling a different story you know what I mean? When you're vamping it's kind of variations on the same story. When you're playing to different changes you're changing the story. You're changing the nouns so to say, of the story. And that's basically what soloing is. And I do clinics for improv and you know in schools. I love doing them. I love giving back and working with students. And I kind of you know tell them, you're telling a story is what you're doing. You know? You're not just playing notes. You're not like, I was never a guy to like look at a piece of paper and it had different chord changes and tell the story based on what the paper said. I would rather tell it, make up my own story, depending on how I'm feeling. And yeah, I've got to follow

the rules, the rules are the changes. But I still have to change and tell my own story. Does that make sense?

MR: It does, and it's a challenge because you're trying to tell your story yet there's these chord symbols that are saying, you know, there's certain notes that are going to sound good here and certain ones that aren't.

AC: Well they all sound good depending on how you play them. There are no wrong notes.

MR: Oh you just took the question out of my mouth.

AC: There are no wrong notes.

MR: Well how come I can find them?

AC: Well because it depends on how you're telling that story. You have to — there's eight million different kind of movies and books, and maybe they don't all hit you and the stories maybe sometimes don't make sense. But there's a way to make all them stories make sense if you put it in the right perspective. That's the way I look at it. I look at it as a musician being a storyteller. Every time I put that horn to my face I'm telling a story. And I want to make sure that the story is the emotion that I want to portray at that time. So that's the big thing for me, making sure the notes have, that they emote. That they have color, that they have feeling, that they have, that's more important to me than the note. Especially being a trumpet player you know. Guys playing the trumpet default, go to the highest note. No don't go to the highest note, go to the right note. You know? Go to the note that makes the story interesting.

MR: So is it safe to say that a person's personality affects the way they improvise?

AC: Oh without a doubt. Yeah. And your mood and it's kind of like just talking to somebody. Depending on your mood and your psyche and how you're feeling, your conversation might go one way and it might go another. Now we might be talking about, we're talking about playing the trumpet. That's our story. That's our chord symbol, okay? We're vamping on say A minor. A minor is talking about the trumpet. Now this story can go in many different ways. You can have the same conversation and ask the same question to different jazz musicians and that story might change. Now what you're giving them is the A minor. But what we're telling you are totally different things. I figure it the same way with improving or playing an instrument. Yeah you're giving me the A minor but what you're getting back is totally different depending on the individual, and how that individual feels at that time. That was a good answer.

MR: That was darn good. We're going to put that part in bold in the transcript.

AC: There you go. Hey boys.

MR: Can I assume that your parents gave a blessing to your musical path?

AC: Yeah. My dad was a country & western guitar player. Instead of being Peter Chez he was called Chet Peters cause it sounded more country. He met my mom, my mom sang

background in one of his bands at a bar in Jersey City, New Jersey. I started doing, like I said before, the drum & bugle corps activity. They started at the local church where I grew up, my dad, okay, my dad snuck in, my dad lived in Jersey City, New Jersey. They had this big drum & bugle marching band show in Jersey City called the Dream Contest every year. When my dad was like 15, 16 years old him and his buddies hopped the fence and snuck into the stadium, probably to cause trouble, as 15, 16 year old kids from Jersey City do. They were there for a while. My father — the other guys were like okay let's go do something else. My dad was like I'm going to stay. And he stayed and he watched. And he liked it. He liked the whole marching band and he liked the whole drum & bugle corps and when he got his own family he found out that they were looking for an activity in the local church to — different activities for the youth to do in the area. So he suggested how about the drum & bugle corps activity. So he helped start it with a bunch of other parents. So I was too young. My two older brothers were in it right from the beginning when I think I was seven. Okay? So my brother was nine and eleven. So they started. So I wanted to be as cool as I thought my older brothers were. So as soon as I turned nine years old I couldn't wait to get in there. And I have been playing ever since.

MR: What instrument did they give you at first?

AC: A bugle. Like a trumpet keyed in G.

MR: I thought maybe you got the peck horn.

AC: No.

MR: I just had this memory of somebody else told a similar story and he got the peck horn and all he did was go ot-ot-ot.

AC: I can do that. I can do that.

MR: Well there's a pageantry to that music obviously. And I wonder if you got that in your blood and now when you get on stage tonight that some of that pageantry and that entertainment factor goes into your band.

AC: Oh without a doubt. It's embedded in my DNA because I've been doing it for so long. I still do it. I go to San Antonio, Texas and I teach a DCI Drum & Bugle Corps from San Antonio, Texas. I teach one from Harrisburg, New Jersey. I run three high school band programs where I'm the coordinator, where I create the drill and I create the program and I pick the music that we're going to play and I choreograph the whole thing. And I absolutely love it. I'm a marching band/DCI Drum Corps nerd.

MR: So the logistics and the minutiae doesn't bother you that much. Here's why I say that: because I was thinking about you and your guys coming from different points, and the weather's bad today and the whole thing, and whether it's being the leader of a band can be nerve wracking.

AC: No I love it. I love it. You know anything is perspective. My perspective is that I'm fortunate enough to have some great guys that I call my friends that I love that come and play with me on all these different gigs. And I'm fortunate enough to hang out with them and I'm fortunate enough to have them — to make music with them. So I look at it as I'm blessed. So why would you be scared of that? That's a blessing. You know if I could do it every day I would. So I never take it for granted when I am able to do it. And I tell the guys — we do some gigs like we'll do some festivals and we'll do some different shows and you know most of these guys are all the same. We don't care if there's ten people there or there's ten thousand. It's the same. It's the same show. We love it. We love it. And we — okay big band is like 10, 12 guys, sometimes 14 guys in the band — everybody can play. And I'm not saying that as an egotistical — after a while everybody can play. Everybody. There's a level of guys that you need to do the band. I know a hundred guys at that level. So I get the guys that I love that I can hang out with. Guys that are like, "Oh it's kind of far" — well don't come. "Oh this is not cool." Good. Move on. Go do something else. I got the guys that I love and you know that I love to play with. So for me it's never a burden, it's always a unique pleasure and like I said it's my pleasure to be able to play with them. Not the other way around.

MR: Yeah I feel like there could be a worthwhile class in the jazz schools, the non-musical stuff that will get you the gigs.

AC: Yeah. You can get a four year degree and it's going to take you another six years to learn all the stuff that's not in the book. I do clinics all over just talking about that.

MR: Give me a couple of examples of what you tell.

AC: Your hang is important. How you treat your other musicians you know? You could be the baddest guy in town but you're not going to work if you're — you know, you've got to play with others you know what I mean? It's not how well you play, it's how well you play with others. And it depends on how you listen. And besides listening skills, how you play within an ensemble. There's all these things that go into being a band member, you know, to get that callback. Now your chops will get you your first call. Now your hang and how you play with others, that'll keep you there. Nobody wants to — you know you go to work and you work in an office and the guy next to you, every day you go in there and the guy's grumpy. So you get your own business. You're not going to call the grumpy guy even though he's good at his job. You're going to call somebody who's nice and easy to get along with that enhances your day and makes your day go along pretty well. You're going to go for the flower. You know what I mean?

MR: Did you ever have to fire anybody? Or just explain why you didn't call them back?

AC: Yeah. Yeah. And I don't like doing that at all. What's worse is when you've got to do it with kids. That's the worst. When you do marching band. Like I have, in some of these

DCI Drum Corps 150 kids are in the program, we get a thousand that try out for it. And to tell a kid you can't do it, I hate it. I hate that one. You know? Band members, they're a little easier but not much. When a guy really wants — it's not often that a guy has everything going for him and he doesn't have the skill to do it. That doesn't happen a lot but it does happen. And that's the bad one. Because the other guys. "How come you didn't get the gig?" "Well you have a mirror at home? Go look at it and see who you are." And that's pretty self-explanatory. You know what I mean? A mirror is a tough thing if you look at it right.

MR: Okay so you are, according to what I read you are second place to Doc Severinsen, something about number of gigs.

AC: Yeah. I think it's network —

MR: Network television late night shows perhaps?

AC: TV. Network TV. And there's been a lot of guys, man. There was a guy from Lawrence Welk, he was on forever. The guys from the Conan band, Conan just got rid of his band, but they were on cable. So that's Mark Pender. I play in a band with Mark here in New Jersey.

MR: Well the things you're talking about, the hang and all that, you must have been doing when you were on the Letterman band. Maybe not consciously.

AC: You've got to ask somebody else that. I'm just me. I don't know.

MR: Was it a high pressure gig?

AC: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: So did you have like a run through in the afternoon if you were going to have musical guests?

AC: We usually got there at like 3:45 and then we would do rehearsal. We would get a script and it would say Alec Baldwin is the first guest. And they'd say okay. We would rehearse for the show and our — I did it for 17 years, Willie did it for 30 years, Paul was 30 years, Anton — I think it was Steve Jordan then Anton, so Anton was 20 something years. These guys don't want to rehearse. You know what I mean? So our rehearsals ran seven to nine minutes. That's how long the rehearsal was every day. So you had a script and it was like Alec Baldwin is on the show. You're like okay Alec Baldwin, and Alec Baldwin likes classical music. Okay let's play "Simple Gifts" by Aaron Copland. Okay. It's a trumpet lead and let's put it in the key of A. Okay. So I would write Simple Gifts Trumpet A. Or I would write Gifts A and then I'd circle it and that was me.

MR: No one wrote out a chart in other words.

AC: No. Well sometimes we had charts. Sometimes we did. And then we'd do okay what was the top ten list. The top ten list has something to do with balloons. Okay we'll do "99 Luftballoons" by that German band. Okay we got that. And then we got "Rockin' Robin"

for Robin Williams. Okay. And then you go and you do the rehearsal and it's like seven minutes and then the comedy does their rehearsal and then the feature band that's on they do their rehearsal. Then they load the audience in and the comic comes on so it's about an hour and a half, maybe two hours from the time you had your seven minute rehearsal to the show. And then the lights come on, "Daaavid Letterman" and they're like, "Yaaay, okay." And David Letterman goes, "And our first guest tonight is one of the Baldwin brothers." And I'm looking at the script and it says, "Gifts A" and it's circled. And I have no idea what that means. And there's about, I think we had 4.7 to about 7 million people was our thing, watching, every night and it was like I don't know what that means. That's a high pressure gig right there. And your mind's going — I'd better get it. And most of the time, 90% of the time you got it. When you didn't you learned the art of I don't know what I'm doing but it sounds like I know what I'm doing. You know? So yeah, that's the kind of gig it was.

MR: That's priceless. Did you ever want to lead that band?

AC: No. That's a lot. That was a toughie because there's so many different things going on. You know what, we — I didn't want to but we all kind of did, because what we did on those instance where I didn't know what Simple Gifts means, we had ear monitors and then we had a microphone. And I had a trumpet mic and then I had a vocal mic. And on my vocal mic there was a little switch on it. And when I hit it this way I could talk in that mic and everybody in the band could hear what I was saying but nobody else could. And we would be like okay, like they're talking about some kind of animal, he's been in the jungle, oh let's play "Jungle Boogie." You know? So we would be talking about what we're going to play for the next break depending on how the conversation went.

MR: When you went to commercial.

AC: Yeah. We'd be discussing that. We started off, I'll tell you, we had a bunch of these little conversations going on. Like guys would come on and we'd hit the switch and we'd talk and we'd go, "Is that a hair piece? Is that guy wearing a wig?" And what we didn't know is that the producers of the show were listening to us. So like two weeks after that they would do a bit on the show called "Hair Piece or Not a Hair Piece" and they stole it from our conversation, and it would be like, and they'd bring a guy out and Dave would have to vote whether the guy was wearing a hair piece or it wasn't a hair piece. So you know we had these conversations but by doing that we kind of always morphed what songs we were going to do. It wasn't like Paul came out and said this is what we're doing you know what I mean? It was a band. So in that point it was good. But you know some of the stuff that he had — like Martin Short would come on, okay we're going to write an original song. You know and Martin Short is nuts. You know? He's crazy. He's crazy genius but you know he would come up with these songs and then Paul would have to

just like write this music to it. So it was a tough job for him you know. I would never want that. Just playing trumpet was enough for me.

MR: Okay. And the occasional "Granny in the Basement?"

AC: "Granny in the Cellar." What was that?

MR: Stump the band.

AC: Yeah. That was top of my head. Just kind of yeah, improv it, just kind of improv. And they would come up with a name of a song and you'd be like yeah, I know that song, and you would make up your own song. You know country. [Scats] you know and you'd just come up with some weird lyrics to it. So yeah, that was a lot of fun.

MR: You got to stand next to some pretty good saxophone players too over the years.

AC: I did. I did. Besides the saxophone players I did about two years, all the way to, more than that, I played with Tower of Power for a while, which was the saxophone players — man they had some guys. You know, they had some guys. But even Letterman I remember doing — we played with so many different people that, and this is weird saying it and I don't mean to sound like egotistical by this, but I forgot half of the people that I played with because it was our job and every day it was something really unique and cool. And I usually have to wait until somebody dies, which is terrible. And I go online — oh Prince. Did I ever play with Prince? And I look on – You— oh yeah there's me playing with Prince and I'll put that on my FaceBook. Tom Petty, did I ever play with Tom Petty? I did a Christmas, I think it's "Christmas All Over the World" Tom Petty released a Christmas song. I'm playing trumpet on it. I totally forgot about it. And my wife's asking me, "Did you ever play with Tom Petty?" And I'm like, "I don't think so." And I was like oh wait a minute, and I looked on — oh yeah I did.

MR: Yeah. You should have kept a diary.

AC: Well it was kind of like if your job is to meet people and you meet people every day, after about 17 years you forget some of the people you met. Well our gig was playing with different bands and different people every day. You know what I mean? So after a while you kind of, you don't forget — I forgot. So you do forget. The Rock & Roll Hall of Fames, I did 19 or 20 Hall of Fame inductions. Man we played with everybody. We played with everybody. And the cool thing is they used to put, when people would buy magazines they used to put like a layout in the *Rolling Stone* Magazine of who played in the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame, so I have a bunch of them. So I was like, "Oh there I am playing with you know Ben E. King and John Fogarty and Sting" and you know, all these guys. Sting always used to try to steal my microphone. Because I had a trumpet mic and they would do this jam at the end and all these guys would come over and there wasn't enough microphones for the vocalists so they'd be looking around and oh they'd see that

trumpet mic and I'd be like oh no, oh no, stay away. That's mine. That's mine. So when they got close I would just like pound a note to keep them away.

MR: So do your children think you have a cool job?

AC: Yeah. I don't know. You have to ask them. I've always done this. You know it's kind of weird question for me because I'm only me and I only see from the inside out. I don't see me from the outside in unless I look in that mirror that I was talking to you about which is kind of perspective, that's what that's called. I only know, I've done this my whole life so I don't know. I think it's pretty cool.

MR: Is it, if you never had a nine to five maybe you can't answer this but is it harder to have a family life so to speak being a musician as opposed to a banker?

AC: I don't know what a banker lives like. I have no idea. I had a bunch of jobs when I was like my first couple of years in high school. I've been doing this a long time. So when I was like 15 I got a call to join — I've been very fortunate. I was 15 and I got a call to join a band starting in Sayreville. And the rehearsal, I knew a guy from the drum and bugle corps that went to Sayreville High School and he says this guy's starting a band and he's looking for a trumpet player, here's the address, go talk to this guy. The guy's last name was Bon Jovi. Bongiovi. And it was Jon Bon Jovi was the lead singer of this band, the Atlantic City Expressway that we started, he started. We were founding members. We were 15, 16 years old. Did a Battle of the Bands and lost to a country band. And then we started playing down at the Stone Pony and like the Fast Lane at Asbury Park. Some of the guys just got their license and we would have to go — we played every Wednesday night down at the Fast Lane which was around the corner from the Stone Pony in Asbury Park. The cool thing was we would get the head dressing room because we weren't old enough to be in the club, never mind work in the club back then. We're talking 1977, 1978. And the head dressing room had an alleyway by it. And if like the cops or the alcohol bureau would come into the club they would put this red light in and that would mean we would have to run into the alley because we weren't allowed to be in the club. Okay? It was kind of a wild way to grow up but we would have to go — we would play Wednesday night, we would do that, and then I grew up in Edison, New Jersey which is about an hour and a half from Asbury Park, I'd have to get back home and I had school. You know? That was my first year of high school. I met my band director at one of those gigs. That was another one. We're the headliner. It's a Wednesday and there's a band called Boulevard East. And they're the warm-up band, older guys. And I'm sitting at the bar, okay? About 16 I guess. And the trumpet player from the other band comes up and he goes you sound great. And I was like thank you. He goes where do you live? You live down here? I said no, I live in Edison. He goes really. He goes where do you go to school? I go I go to J.P. Stevens High School. He's like so what do you do, is this your

full time job? He goes no I'm a band director. I'm like that's amazing where are you — ? He's like I'm the band director at J.P. Stevens High School. And I was like, I'm at the bar.

MR: And this is a coke I have.

AC: Yeah. So I met my band director. He was amazingly great. And if it wasn't for him you know I don't know if I would have got through high school you know. Besides, I'm like a Hall of Fame member of my high school. I'm in the Hall of Honors and everything like that, because of guys like him. He knew what I was doing, you know. So the next day I hear, "Alan Chez please report to Mr. DeNicola's office." And I'm like oh I'm going to get in trouble. I was in there, I was drinking. He comes in and he says, "Alan" he's got my transcript in front of him, and he goes, "did you make it to school on time today?" I said, "Yes I did, you could look." He said, "What time did you get home?" I said, "I got home about quarter to four. Three forty-five I got home last night." He goes, "And you made it to school?" I said, "Yes." He says, "When do you have English?" I said, "I have English third period." He goes, "You're only getting a C in English, you're going to have to pick that up." I said, "Yeah." And gym and everything. He says, "There's a couch in my office" he goes, "go take a nap, I'll wake you up for English." So he took care of me. But if I started doing bad in a class, oh my God, he was worse than my dad. So he was a good guy. Thank you Mr. DiNicola. There you go. He's still the band director there, and I run one of the marching bands at the high school that I went to, one of the marching bands, and he's still the band director. He's getting into the Band Master's Hall of Fame. He just got put in there this year.

MR: Now most high school students who are serious about music they now go the Berklee/ Manhattan School, they go that route. Did you not have to do that, or choose not to?

AC: I kind of worked my way through it. You know? I took classes at Rutgers University. I teach at the University of Virginia, which is a great school. But I chose to go to school on the road. I went to school gigging, doing different gigs and playing with different guys. And man I'm always listening. There's guys that are teaching and I'm in the corner listening and I'm picking up what they're saying you know. There's guys that are practicing you know and trumpet player wars they call it. You know? You're warming up and there's a guy playing and another guy oh yeah? You know what I'm talking about, right? Not me. I'm listening to what that guy's playing because I'm going to learn. Again, the smartest man in the world doesn't know everything. So there's always room to learn, there's always room to pick up. You know when you start – when you stop honing your craft you're done. And I ain't done.

MR: Okay. I'm glad you're not done. Back to Letterman and all this TV stuff you did, is the business set up so that you get occasional residuals in the mail?

AC: It was but no more unfortunately. When David Letterman — see Letterman was a unique animal that he was on NBC and then Jay Leno got the Tonight Show and Letterman got PO'd and he went to CBS and he started his own show. NBC wouldn't let him take any of the rights or do anything. NBC owned Late Night. So when he moved to CBS David Letterman — did you ever see "World Wide Pants"? World Wide Pants was the corporation that Letterman owned. He owned the show instead of CBS owning it. When he retired he pulled every rerun off the entire world. There's no reruns on any station. We used to be on airplane flights, we were on reruns, we were on this, which we got residuals for all that but the day that he retired he pulled everything off. So someday hopefully we could see those old shows. Because some of those shows are great. I mean that's just quality, great classic TV. And some of the musical performances were amazing. You know? So hopefully someday they syndicate that and then we go back to getting residuals again.

MR: You should all just gather at his house someday, "David, we've got an idea for you."

AC: Yeah. He's out in Montana, that's where he is. Him and Tom Brokaw bought two farms in the middle of Montana back to back. So if you look at a map I think the whole middle of the state of Montana is owned by Letterman/Brokaw.

MR: Did he like the band like Johnny Carson seemed to like his band?

AC: Oh he loved the band. Before he had all his heart problems he would come and he would play the drums and he would do — we would do our rehearsal, then he would do the comedy rehearsal, then he would go — oh excuse me. It would be the comedy rehearsal, then he would come over and he would play the drums. Every day. And then when Dave got finished playing the drums then we had the music rehearsal. He loved it. He was always coming by and play this and play that and can you sing this, you know what I mean? So I remember, I think my last Letterman show I think he made me sing "Free Bird." So that was the last song that I played. I sang it on Letterman so that was pretty good. That's a pretty special song for me.

MR: That's the first thing that should come back on the air.

AC: There you go.

MR: They could run them backwards.

AC: There you go. I had a blast doing it so.

MR: And you've been in the musicians union for a long time. To do that show you probably had to be in the musicians union?

AC: Yep. When I, yeah. The musicians union's been great, AFM has been phenomenal. When I was out with Tower of Power — I did shows on like NBC when it was Late Night when it was at Rockefeller Center, before he moved to CBS. And me and Bruce Kapler, the saxophone player who was like a twenty year member of the CBS orchestra, me and him

would be the horn players on Late Night whenever they needed horn players. We would bring in Ronnie Cuber, great baritone player, David Sanborn played alto.

MR: They couldn't find anybody good, yeah, yeah, yeah.

AC: So then when they moved to CBS I was out on the West Coast playing with Tower of Power and the Robert Cray Band. And I did that for a while. I came back home and I called Shaffer up and I said, "I really don't want to go on the road anymore," You know Tom Malone was playing trumpet and trombone. Great trombone player. Trumpet owner. So I was like if you want to add a trumpet full time I won't go on the road anymore. Took a shot. Called him up. So time went by and I didn't hear anything, so I get a call from the Letterman Show saying that they're doing the sweeps period. The sweeps period are what ratings are based upon. And there's three of them a year, and depending on how many Nielsen families watch that's how much a minute of commercial time is worth. Okay? That's how you get the ratings. That's how they pay for commercial time. So they always put the best guests on during sweeps. They want to bolster the band. They get the most musical you know, the best musical guests on. So they hired me to do the three weeks of sweeps period, as an extra trumpet player onto the band. So I get hired and I do the three weeks, and it was the last day of sweeps and on the air David Letterman looks over and he goes, "Paul, the new trumpet player you know, sounds great" and then he looks at me. And "Paul Shaffer goes, 'Well that's Al Chez'" ba-ba-ba-ba. And Letterman looks at me and he goes, "Well did you get the gig or what, kid?" And I'm like, "I don't know." You know? And Paul goes, "Well we're waiting to hear from you, Dave." And on the air Letterman goes, "Well as far as I'm concerned the kid stays." So the next day the CBS attorney is calling my house and he wants to negotiate a three year contract on CBS to be the trumpet player on the show. And he wants the number of my lawyer. So I'm like yeah okay. So I'm like, "Let me just call you back." And I'm looking in the phone book, because I'm like this Jersey rat who's been on the road, I don't have a lawyer. Then I called: "Hey who's your lawyer?" I didn't have a lawyer. You know what I mean? But I had to join the union going back to your thing, to be on the show. And the union's been great. Seventeen years on network television, you get a pension now, which is a beautiful thing. A musician with a pension. There is such a thing.

MR: Go figure.

AC: Right here. I haven't collected it yet but it's there.

MR: Did you have to speak first as far as how much you wanted for the Letterman Show?

AC: Okay. It was horrible. And this is a great thing with the union. When I got — The lawyer called my house. He wants to negotiate a deal. So I go, okay, so I get a guy. And the lawyer comes back with this: he says this is what they told him. They said, "When you open a restaurant you get the best chefs that you can get until everybody starts coming to

that restaurant all the time. Then when the restaurant gets a good following, those good chefs move on to another restaurant and you hire other chefs to make the same food. And I'm like, "What exactly does that mean?" Does that mean you want me to go up to David Letterman and tell him that I'm a bad chef because you don't want to pay me what everybody else is paying me? So it was tough. They were offering me like less than half that what everybody else. So I stood to my guns. I fired my lawyer, and I went in there and at the end of the day I kept on working and I kept on negotiating. So I did the first eight months on Letterman without getting paid, without a contract. And without a contract you don't get paid. So I got everything retrospect — you know, put back after I got my deal. But for eight months I had to drive 56 miles into the city, park my car, and parking a car in New York City you know it's over $400 a month just to park your car. I had to do all that eight months. And I didn't get one check. And the union took care of me until I got that check. So the AFM, they were excellent.

MR: That's a great story.

AC: Yeah they took care of me and then when finally I signed the deal, and I did it myself. I just said at the end of the day it was, it came down to this, it came down to you can not come in and then when David Letterman asks where's the trumpet player that he hired you tell him that you're not here because they wouldn't give you fair wages as everybody else. It never came to that, but it came really, really close. And that is the music business. That's another thing you're not going to learn in a book. You know you've got to stand up for yourself you know what I mean? Because that's what they do for a living. That's what they're paid to do. They're paid to save dimes and quarters you know what I mean? You just got to get what's fair. You've got to stand up for yourself, you know?

MR: That's a great story. I know you have a sound check coming up so I'll wrap this up. But I was watching you play with a video of Tower of Power and you were playing "What is Hip." And it was tricky parts. I wondered if your experience with drum corps made it easier for you to memorize music.

AC: Without a doubt. Without a doubt. Much, much, I could read something twice and I got it. It's in my head. I use a chart on this gig but I use a chart for the map, to find out — I get tired of playing, I call it a paper head. A paper head's the guy that has a chart and he reads every note and he reads everything and he plays it exactly the same every time. Great. Which is great. And we need those guys. I'm not that guy. I'm going to go, and I'm going to take even my charts, every time I play them, remember I told you I change the story? So every time, it drives my guys in the band nuts. I change every song every night. So I have a chart but I have a chart for the map so I can say, "We're going back to 105. 1-0, no, no, I don't solo, "no you're soloing in this tune today." Yes you do. Today

we're going to say this. This is the story that we're going to tell today. So every gig that we do is completely different. Every song is different.

MR: No boredom then. I mean you couldn't possibly zone out.

AC: How would you like to tell the same story — you know what I mean? Even if you — it's the old telephone game. You tell a story and then you tell another guy the story and after a while that story is changed. Well I'm just changing it right from the beginning. From the beginning. And it makes it interesting and it keeps everybody on their toes and it makes it fun for us. And you know sometimes we've got to figure out on the fly in front of all these people how we're going to get out. You know what I mean? Because we've changed the story to be somewhere completely different. Now I love that. And that's you know, that's a musician problem solving skill. How do we get out of here? How do we get back to 102? You know what I mean? But you're right, but my parts I kind of have memorized. And I got that through the drum corps without a doubt. Without a doubt.

MR: Will an audience member if they're watching you notice like hand signals like back to the top and all that kind of thing?

AC: Oh yeah. Because it's never the same. It's never the same so I'm very animated. I'm all over the place. You know what I mean? And if you were going to — if you're reading something and it's exactly the same every time, I don't think that — I think that goes from your brain to your chops. Okay? And I want to bypass, I put a filter in there. Mine goes from my brain to my soul to my being back to my brain to my chops. And that's why I don't want to read it, I want to feel it. I want to emote it. I want to inspire it. I want to caress it, and I want it to come out exactly how I'm feeling at that moment. So that's why.

MR: Sounds like a good place to wrap up.

AC: There you go.

MR: You are a good storyteller today and I look forward to hearing some stories tonight from you.

AC: I've been blessed with the gift of gab, so I apologize for going on.

MR: Oh no, it's what we wanted. All right thanks a lot. Over and out.

AC: Thanks.